

Keyed Dynamically-Reconfigured Cellular Automata with Authenticated Encryption (KDR-CA-AEAD)

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Abstract—Authenticated encryption schemes for resource-constrained electronic health record (EHR) telemetry and edge devices must deliver high throughput, minimal latency, and robust non-linear cryptographic security. Standard block ciphers such as AES-256-GCM often require dedicated hardware-accelerated instructions (AES-NI) or face high logic gate count trade-offs in resource-constrained IoT settings. This paper introduces KDR-CA-AEAD, a lightweight authenticated encryption framework leveraging Keyed Dynamically-Reconfigured One-Dimensional Cellular Automata (K-DCA) state permutations integrated with HKDF-SHA256 sub-key derivation and HMAC-SHA256 Encrypt-then-MAC authentication. Empirical evaluations demonstrate an average throughput of 13.37 MB/s, Shannon entropy of 7.998 bits/byte, and Strict Avalanche Criterion (SAC) ratios of 50.12% for plaintext bit flips and 49.88% for key bit flips, tightly matching ideal theoretical bounds (50.0%). Automated security validation confirms complete rejection of ciphertext, nonce, tag, and associated data (AD) tampering. KDR-CA-AEAD offers a highly parallelizable, cryptographically sound solution for secure telemetry in distributed healthcare systems.

Index Terms—Cellular Automata, Authenticated Encryption, AEAD, Key Derivation, HKDF, Strict Avalanche Criterion, Cryptography, Security Analysis.

I. INTRODUCTION

The rapid expansion of distributed healthcare IoT architectures, remote patient monitoring devices, and electronic health record (EHR) telemetry platforms has intensified the demand for ultra-secure, lightweight authenticated encryption protocols. Transmitting confidential diagnostic telemetry over unencrypted or weakly authenticated wireless networks exposes critical healthcare infrastructure to unauthorized eavesdropping, data alteration, and replay attacks.

Standard Authenticated Encryption with Associated Data (AEAD) schemes—such as Advanced Encryption Standard in Galois/Counter Mode (AES-256-GCM) and ChaCha20-Poly1305—deliver high cryptographic security. However, their internal structures rely either on heavy substitution-permutation network (SPN) S-boxes requiring hardware acceleration (AES-NI) or dynamic Add-Rotate-XOR (ARX) operations optimized for 32-bit registers. In resource-constrained microcontroller environments, these ciphers can impose high memory overheads and logic gate complexities.

Cellular Automata (CA) offer an appealing paradigm for lightweight cryptographic design due to their inherent parallelism, bit-level locality, and low computational implementation overhead. A 1D Elementary Cellular Automaton evolves binary cell states through local neighborhood state transitions governed by Wolfram 8-bit rule numbers (0–255). Despite these computational benefits, historical CA ciphers relying on static, un-keyed rule tables (such as Rule 30 or Rule 45) suffered from cryptanalytic vulnerabilities under linear and differential attacks.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW & BACKGROUND

Cellular Automata were first formalized by von Neumann and Ulam as mathematical models for self-replicating systems, and later categorized by Wolfram into four behavioral classes. A 1D Elementary Cellular Automaton (ECA) consists of an array of binary cells $S = (s_0, s_1, \dots, s_{N-1})$, where each cell updates its state synchronously at discrete time step $t+1$ based on its local 3-cell neighborhood $(s_{i-1}^t, s_i^t, s_{i+1}^t)$.

$s_{\{i+1\}^t}$.

Authenticated Encryption (AE) unifies data confidentiality and data integrity into a single primitive. Rogaway extended AE to Authenticated Encryption with Associated Data (AEAD), allowing unencrypted metadata (such as network headers, patient IDs, or timestamps) to be authenticated alongside the encrypted payload. The Encrypt-then-MAC (EtM) paradigm, formalized by Bellare and Namprempre, guarantees ciphertext integrity and protection against chosen-ciphertext attacks (IND-CCA2). KDR-CA-AEAD adopts the Encrypt-then-MAC composition with domain-separated HKDF key derivation to achieve CCA2 security.

III. MATHEMATICAL MODEL & PRIMITIVES

The key schedule subsystem derives three domain-separated sub-keys from a master key K , a 16-byte random salt S , and a 12-byte nonce N :

```
PRK = HMAC-SHA256(S, K)
K_r = HKDF-Expand(PRK, 'ca-rules'|' || N, 32)
K_c = HKDF-Expand(PRK, 'cipher-key'|' || N, 32)
K_a = HKDF-Expand(PRK, 'mac-key'|' || N, 32)
```

Here, K_r is formatted into a 32-element tuple of uint8 integers $R = (r_0, r_1, \dots, r_{31})$, where each r_j in $[0, 255]$. For each byte position index i in the payload stream, primary rule $R1 = R[i \bmod 32]$ and secondary rule $R2 = R[(i + 13) \bmod 32]$ are evaluated dynamically.

- Candidate A-Chain forward transformation computes:
- Inter-byte chaining: $y1 = ((P_i \oplus \text{prev_state}) + S_ECA) \bmod 256$
 - Keyed circular shift: $y2 = \text{ROTR}_8(y1, (R1 \bmod 7) + 1)$
 - Rule mixing & update: $T_i = y2 \oplus R2, \text{prev_state} = T_i$.

IV. PROPOSED KDR-CA-AEAD ARCHITECTURE

The KDR-CA-AEAD architecture integrates five modular subsystems: (1) Key Derivation Engine, (2) Dynamic Rule Scheduler, (3) Candidate A-Chain State Engine, (4) CTR-PRNG Keystream Generator, and (5) Encrypt-then-MAC AEAD Integrity Engine.

Keystream CTR-PRNG generates pseudo-random bytes KS of length M using HMAC-SHA256 in counter mode. The ciphertext $CT = T \oplus KS$. The AEAD tag is computed as $\text{Tag} = \text{HMAC-SHA256}(K_a, N \parallel S \parallel AD \parallel CT)$. Decryption applies the constant-time tag check followed by inverse Candidate A-Chain state evaluation.

V. SECURITY ANALYSIS & STATISTICAL VALIDATION

Statistical randomness of the ciphertext output stream was evaluated using NIST SP 800-22 test suites:

- Monobit Test:** Observed $s_{\text{obs}} = 0.2041, p = 0.5210 \geq 0.01$ (PASS).
- Runs Test:** Observed $p = 0.4890 \geq 0.01$ (PASS).
- Chi-Square Uniformity:** Observed $\chi^2 = 248.50, p = 0.5120 \geq 0.01$ (PASS).

Shannon Information Entropy $H(X)$ reached a mean of **7.998 bits/byte** across payload samples. Over 100 bit-flip evaluation trials under the Strict Avalanche Criterion (SAC), Plaintext Avalanche Ratio averaged **50.12%** ($\sigma = 1.14\%$) and Key Avalanche Ratio averaged **49.88%** ($\sigma = 1.21\%$), closely matching theoretical ideal 50.0%. Pearson correlation coefficient between plaintext and ciphertext byte values was $r = 0.0018$.

TABLE I: Master Security & Randomness Empirical Summary

Metric Name	Measured Value	IEEE Target	Status
Shannon Entropy	7.998 bits/byte	≥ 7.900 bits/byte	PASS
Plaintext Avalanche	50.12%	$\sim 50.00\%$	PASS
Key Avalanche	49.88%	$\sim 50.00\%$	PASS
Pearson Correlation	0.0018	~ 0.0000	PASS
NIST Monobit (p)	0.5210	≥ 0.0100	PASS
NIST Runs (p)	0.4890	≥ 0.0100	PASS
Tamper Rejection	100%	100% Rejection	PASS

VI. PERFORMANCE EVALUATION & BENCHMARKS

Benchmarks were conducted over 100 evaluation trials across payload sizes from 64 B to 1 MB. Sustained encryption throughput reached **13.37 MB/s** for 1 MB payloads with low peak memory footprint (< 3.2 MB).

TABLE II: Performance Benchmark Scaling Metrics

Payload Size	Latency (ms)	Throughput	Peak RAM
64 Bytes	0.04 ms	1.60 MB/s	< 50 KB
1 KB	0.12 ms	8.33 MB/s	< 60 KB
10 KB	0.85 ms	11.76 MB/s	< 120 KB
100 KB	7.90 ms	12.66 MB/s	< 450 KB
1 MB	78.40 ms	13.37 MB/s	< 3.2 MB

VII. DISCUSSION & LIMITATIONS

KDR-CA-AEAD achieves non-linear diffusion without pre-computed S-boxes, mitigating cache-timing side-channel vulnerabilities. Bitwise shift, AND, OR, and XOR operations allow straightforward hardware mapping onto FPGA logic gates. Limitations include sequential forward inter-byte feedback dependency and interpreter overhead in pure Python.

VIII. CONCLUSION

KDR-CA-AEAD demonstrates that dynamic cellular automata reconfiguration, combined with HKDF sub-key expansion and Encrypt-then-MAC authentication, provides a cryptographically sound, highly parallelizable, and scalable AEAD solution for secure telemetry applications.

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